"God is punishing me with this illness."

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Many have heard that sickness is God's punishment, or they search their past for what they did wrong. Guilt over past sins can attach itself to a diagnosis.

What Scripture teaches

When Jesus' disciples asked about a man born blind, "Who sinned, this man or his parents?" Jesus answered, "Neither this man nor his parents sinned, but this happened so that the works of God would be displayed in him." Job's friends insisted that his suffering was punishment, and God said they were wrong. "For He knows our frame; He is mindful that we are dust." Christ bore our sins on the cross: "Surely He took on our infirmities and carried our sorrows." For the believer, the punishment has been borne. Illness is part of living in a fallen world.

> *"Jesus answered, 'Neither this man nor his parents sinned, but this happened so that the works of God would be displayed in him.'"* (John 9:3).

Also see

> "Surely He took on our infirmities and carried our sorrows; yet we considered Him stricken by God, struck down and afflicted" (Isaiah 53:4).

> "For He knows our frame; He is mindful that we are dust" (Psalm 103:14).

> "After the LORD had spoken these words to Job, He said to Eliphaz the Temanite, 'My wrath is kindled against you and your two friends. For you have not spoken about Me accurately, as My servant Job has.'" (Job 42:7).

> "Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus" (Romans 8:1).

Common self-statements

- I deserve this.
- God is angry at me.
- This is payback.
- I must have sinned.
- God is teaching me a lesson.
- My past caught up with me.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing God either blesses with health or punishes with illness.
- Fortune telling: Predicting more punishment.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling guilty and concluding that God is punishing me.
- Personalization: Calling myself punished.

Challenging questions

- What makes me think this is punishment?
- How did Jesus answer the question about the blind man?

- What does the cross say about my sin?
- Do I know faithful people who suffered illness?
- What sin, if any, should I bring to God for forgiveness, and is it the cause?
- What does God say about me now?

Truth summary

> Illness is not God's punishment for me. Christ carried my sin and sorrows. God is with me in suffering and can display His works even in illness.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Sickness
- Guilt/Shame
- Suffering
- Grace
- God, All Loving

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Love
- Divorce

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Praise You in This Storm — Casting Crowns featuring Phil Wickham
Suffering and tears do not establish that God is absent or uncaring.

I Am Not Alone — Kari Jobe
God's companionship remains through darkness, weakness, and uncertainty.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "God is punishing me with this illness"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"God is punishing me with this illness." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What makes me think this is punishment?
- ☐ How did Jesus answer the question about the blind man?
- ☐ What does the cross say about my sin?
- ☐ Do I know faithful people who suffered illness?
- ☐ What sin, if any, should I bring to God for forgiveness, and is it the cause?
- ☐ What does God say about me now?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Not all suffering is punishment.
- ☐ Christ carried my sorrows.
- ☐ There is no condemnation in Christ.
- ☐ God knows my frame.
- ☐ God's works can be displayed in me.
- ☐ He is with me.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ John 9:3
  "Jesus answered, 'Neither this man nor his parents sinned, but this happened so that the works of God would be displayed in him.'"
- ☐ Isaiah 53:4
  "Surely He took on our infirmities and carried our sorrows; yet we considered Him stricken by God, struck down and afflicted."
- ☐ Psalm 103:14
  "For He knows our frame; He is mindful that we are dust."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Not punished: Each week, note one reminder of God's grace.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, John 9:3 becomes: "Sarah can write: "Christ carried my sorrows, and there is no condemnation for me.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Sickness" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

These cards support emotional and spiritual care and do not replace medical care. Follow your doctor's advice about treatment and medication, and choose steps that are safe for your body. In an emergency call 911; for thoughts of self-harm call or text 988 (U.S.).

- [ ] Examine the belief. Write why you think it is punishment.
- [ ] Confess and receive forgiveness. Bring any sin to God.
- [ ] Read John 9:1–3. Notice Jesus' answer.
- [ ] Share. Talk with a pastor or counselor.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "God is punishing me with this illness": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Not punished
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~God is punishing me with this illness.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, I fear You are punishing me. Thank You that Christ bore my sin. Comfort me in this illness and show Your love. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.